**before Uddhav Thackeray took over in 2019.**

**A.** He [Thackeray] said he did not want to become the CM and wanted a Shiv Sainik to head the state. Who was that Shiv Sainik? It was me. If not me, another Shiv Sainik could have been chosen to fulfill Balasaheb's [late Shiv Sena supremo Bal Thackeray] dream of a Shiv Sainik becoming the CM. But he [Uddhav Thackeray] chose to sit in the chair himself. He acted in a manner that was selfish and self-seeking. He asked Pawar Saheb to suggest his name for the post. After becoming the CM, he neglected the party and Shiv Sainiks. The Shiv Sainiks were being demoralised, and MLAs were very upset as they were not being given any developmental funds for their constituencies.

**Q. Has the entry of deputy CM Ajit Pawar and his NCP in the government reduced the BJP's dependence on you? The cabinet expansion is also pending.**

**A.** Who is saying this? Uddhav Thackeray? The people are not saying this. Our importance has not declined. We have secured 15 Lok Sabha seats. The cabinet expansion will take place.

**Q. As the CM, what is your dream project?**

**A.** Basic infrastructure and connectivity are important for Maharashtra. This includes roads, connectivity for its 720 km coastline, as well as air and rail connectivity. If any state is to progress, it must have good infrastructure and connectivity... When work on the 337 km metro routes in Mumbai will be completed, this will take private vehicles off the roads. Traffic congestion will also decline due to flyovers and bypasses. The state will progress due to all-round development. As John F. Kennedy said, "American roads are good not because America is rich, but America is rich because American roads are good." ■







Photographs by ANI



**ACT NATURALLY**
(Clockwise from below) Rachana Banerjee, Dev, Locket Chatterjee; Hiran Chatterjee

MANDATE 2024 | WEST BENGAL |

# Star Wars in the Poll Firmament

## Locket and Rachana in Hooghly, Hiran and Dev in Ghatal—two pairs of actor-turned-politicians slug it out in the polls

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

On March 3, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee appeared on the immensely popular television game show for women, *Didi No. 1*. As millions watched, the Trinamool Congress chief read out her poems, painted, danced with tribal women and participated in games. Why this surprise appearance, many wondered. They got the answer a week later, when *Didi No. 1* host Rachana Banerjee—a former icon of Odia cinema who has also acted in Bengali, Hindi and South Indian films—was named the TMC candidate from the Hooghly constituency, which went to vote on May 20. Rachana took on incumbent BJP MP Locket Chatterjee, herself an actor-turned-politician. A popular entertainer, Mamata must have reasoned, has a better chance to take down a former TV star.

If the TMC hit upon this tactic to win back Hooghly, the BJP had exactly the same plan in mind. It nominated Hiranmoy (or Hiran) Chatterjee—an actor-turned-BJP MLA—for the Ghatal seat, currently held by one of Bengali cinema's stars, Deepak Adhikari. Deepak, known by his screen name Dev, has been winning the seat since 2014 for the TMC. Though Dev had decided to quit after his second term, he changed his mind after Mamata and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee convinced him to contest again. Ghatal goes to the polls on May 25.

Both pairs of celebrities have shared screen space in the past. Locket and Hiran started their political careers with the TMC before switching to the BJP in 2015 and 2021 respectively.

In 2019, Locket snatched the Hooghly seat from the TMC's Ratna De Nag, chief of the women's wing of the BJP's state unit between 2017 and 2020, and later one of its five general secretaries. However, she soon fell out with party workers. In 2021, the TMC won all seven assembly segments in Hooghly; Locket herself was defeated